ON A HIGH HORSE

ASHISH LIMAYE, 32

Sport: ***EQUESTRIAN***

Discipline: Eventing

Claim to fame: Gold at Asian Equestrian Championships, 2025



FEI GLOBAL

There's something touching when riders talk about their horses, sounding something between a parent and a doting pet owner. Ashish Limaye was driving with Willy Be Dun to a competition in Sopot, Poland, when INDIA TODAY asked him to describe the "lucky horse" he first saw on Instagram. Willy's performance in Sopot would help Limaye secure qualification for both the Asian and the World Games. "Nobody likes to deal with him, for he bullies people around," says Limaye of 14-year-old Willy, one of the seven horses he looks after in Germany, his training base for the last four-and-a-half years. Life there is a handful with the rider tending to horses morning to evening.

"Here we have to do physical activities that an Indian equestrian doesn't have to do—cleaning the stables, feeding horses, taking them to the fields...and then the riding," he says. Acclimatising to this work ethic has enabled him to blossom from a show jumping specialist to eventing—the gold standard of equestrian disciplines that also involves dressage and cross-country.

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Limaye is backed by the Embassy International Riding School in Bengaluru, where he was an instructor. "In India, I won everything for two years and had hit a plateau when Embassy approached with the sponsorship," he says. Born in a family of doctors in Pune, Limaye finished his mechanical engineering after his father assured his support for Limaye's dream to be an equestrian athlete.

Asian Games 2026 will be a redemption tour for Limaye, who had an uncharacteristically blank moment at the past Games when he missed a jump in dressage and forfeited a medal. "It has never happened before or since," he says. Limaye will be relying on his rapport with Willy to overcome every hurdle with eclat. ■

—Suhani Singh